Miss Two, Win Chicken

How the predictions work, in two pages · November 5, 2026 · data through November 2, 2026

What it predicts

For each upcoming game, the chance that **one visiting player misses both free throws of a trip to the line in the 4th quarter**, the moment the crowd wins a free chicken sandwich. Each game is a yes or no; the model puts a probability on the yes before tip-off. Over the last three seasons the answer was yes in 15.5% of road games, about one in six.

The data

- Every play of 3,797 NBA regular-season games since October 2023, including 48,233 fourth-quarter free throws: who shot, the trip position ("1 of 2", "2 of 2"), and make or miss.
- Past seasons come from the NBA's play-by-play feed; 2026-27 and the remaining schedule come from ESPN. Both are public archives on GitHub, and they match exactly on the 2025-26 games they share.
- Current through Nov 2, 2026, and refreshed every afternoon by a scheduled job.

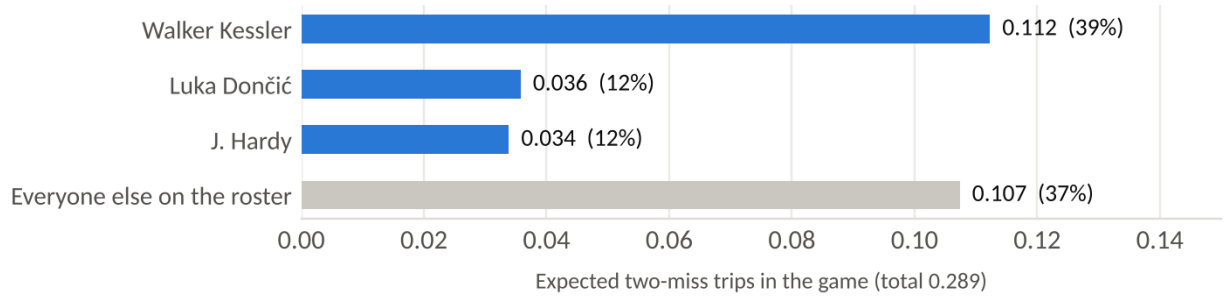
The model

It is built on players, because a team's promo history barely repeats from one season to the next while free throw shooting does. For each game:

1. **Who is playing:** visiting players who appeared in the team's last three games.
2. **Late trips:** each player's 4th-quarter two- and three-shot trips per game, this season blended with last.
3. **Chance of two misses:** $(1 - FT\%)^2$, with FT% pulled toward the league average when attempts are few.
4. **Home team's late fouling:** how often it sends opponents to the line in the 4th, relative to the league.

Multiplying 1-3 and adding across the roster, scaled by 4, gives the expected number of two-miss trips, λ. A fit on past seasons turns it into a chance: $1.21\lambda / (1 + 1.21\lambda)$.

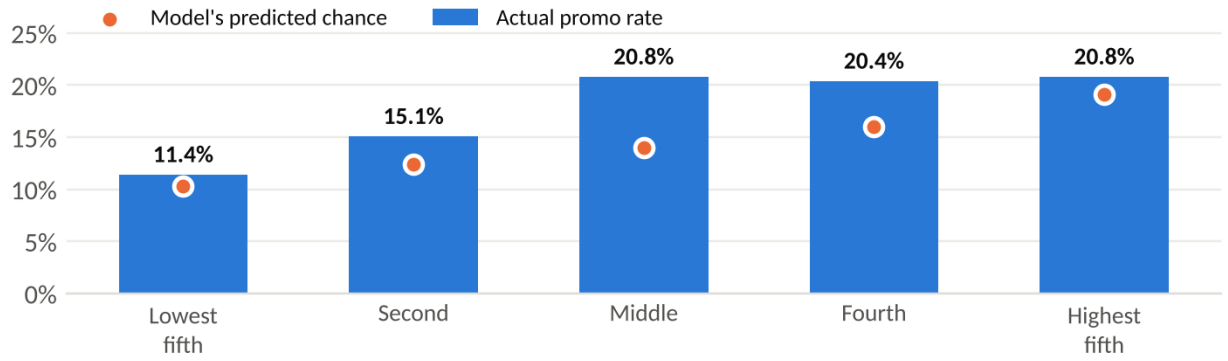
Example: Lakers at Bucks, Wednesday, Nov 11



Walker Kessler, a 66% free throw shooter who gets to the line late almost once a game, carries 39% of the risk. The roster adds up to 0.289 expected two-miss trips, a **26%** chance, the highest of the coming week.

How well it works

Tested on every 2025-26 game (1,225), using only information from before each tip-off. The model ranks games better than a team's own track record (AUC 0.572 vs. 0.538, where 0.5 is a coin flip), but the edge is modest: the games it rated lowest hit 11.4% of the time, and the top fifth 20.8%.



2025-26 games grouped by the model's chance, lowest to highest

Bars: how often the promo actually happened in each fifth of games. Dots: what the model predicted.

Best chances in the next seven days

Date	Game	Chance	Most likely to miss (FT%)
Wed, Nov 11	Lakers at Bucks	26.0%	Walker Kessler (66%), Luka Dončić (79%)
Tue, Nov 10	Heat at Jazz	25.9%	Giannis Antetokounmpo (65%), Donovan Mitchell (68%)
Fri, Nov 6	Timberwolves at Pelicans	24.1%	Rudy Gobert (53%), J. Kuminga (71%)
Mon, Nov 9	Lakers at Hawks	23.8%	Walker Kessler (66%), Luka Dončić (79%)
Sun, Nov 8	Heat at Kings	23.2%	Giannis Antetokounmpo (65%), Donovan Mitchell (68%)

An average remaining game sits at 16%.

Keep in mind

- **A lean, not a lock.** Even the best game is about one in four, so the list is most useful for comparing nights, for example to decide which home games get extra promo staff or social posts.
- **A snapshot of who is playing.** Rosters come from each team's last three games, so injuries and trades after the data date are not reflected until the next refresh.
- **Where to go deeper.** The dashboard updates daily with every upcoming game. The full seven-page version walks through each step, the data checks and the limits.